

Major Strands of Sociology – UPSC Comparison

A thinker-linked reference for building analytical, multi-perspective UPSC answers

1. Strand-by-Strand Comparison

Strand / Perspective	Core Idea / What It Studies	Major Thinkers	Method / Key Concepts	Major Criticism	Whose Idea Can Be Used Against It (UPSC)?
Positivism	Society can be studied scientifically using observation, empirical facts and causal laws	Auguste Comte, Durkheim	Scientific method, observation, comparison, social facts	Ignores subjective meanings and lived experiences	Max Weber → Verstehen; Schutz → phenomenology; Mead/Blumer → meanings through interaction
Functionalism	Society is a system of interdependent parts working toward order, stability and equilibrium	Durkheim, Parsons, Merton	Social system, integration, functions, equilibrium; manifest & latent functions	Overemphasises stability; neglects conflict and inequality	Marx → class conflict; Dahrendorf → authority/conflict; Coser → functions of conflict
Structural Functionalism	Social structures perform functions necessary for system maintenance	Parsons, Merton	AGIL, pattern variables, manifest/latent functions, equilibrium	Conservative/status-quo bias; assumes consensus	Marx, Dahrendorf, C. Wright Mills → power/conflict; Garfinkel → actors construct social order
Conflict Perspective / Marxism	Society is characterised by inequality, domination and conflict over resources and power	Karl Marx, Engels	Class struggle, mode of production, alienation, exploitation, ideology	Economic determinism; underestimates culture, status and individual agency	Weber → class + status + party; Durkheim → consensus/integration; Interactionists → micro-level meaning
Weberian / Interpretative Sociology	Sociology should understand subjective meanings attached to social action	Max Weber	Verstehen, social action, ideal type, rationalisation, authority	Difficult to establish objective/general laws; can underplay structures	Marx → material/economic structures; Durkheim/Positivists → objective social facts
Phenomenology	Social reality is constructed through people's everyday experiences and consciousness	Edmund Husserl, Alfred Schutz	Lifeworld, intersubjectivity, stock of knowledge, typification	Highly subjective; difficult to generalise; neglects wider structures/power	Marx → structural inequality; Durkheim → external social facts; Giddens → structure-agency connection
Symbolic Interactionism	Society emerges through interaction and meanings attached to symbols	Mead, Cooley, Herbert Blumer, Goffman	Self, looking-glass self, significant/generalised others, definition of situation, labelling	Micro-level focus; neglects large-scale structures and power	Marx → class/power; Parsons → macro institutions; Feminists → gendered power structures
Ethnomethodology	Studies how ordinary people produce and maintain social order in everyday life	Harold Garfinkel	Breaching experiments, indexicality, reflexivity, practical reasoning	Excessively micro; ignores historical/institutional structures	Marx/Weber → macro power/authority; Giddens → structuration
Exchange Theory	Social relationships involve cost-benefit calculations and reciprocal exchange	George Homans, Peter Blau	Rewards, costs, reciprocity, exchange	Reduces complex social relations to rational calculation	Durkheim → moral solidarity; Mauss → gift and obligation; Marx → exploitation
Feminist Perspective	Social institutions and knowledge are shaped by gender inequality and patriarchy	Simone de Beauvoir, Ann Oakley, Sylvia Walby, Judith Butler	Patriarchy, gender socialisation, public/private divide, intersectionality	Some versions criticised for treating women as a homogeneous category	Crenshaw → intersectionality; Butler → challenges fixed gender categories
Postmodernism	Rejects one universal explanation; society is fragmented, plural and socially constructed	Lyotard, Baudrillard, Foucault	Grand narratives, simulacra, discourse, power/knowledge	Relativism; difficulty explaining material inequality	Marxists → material structures remain important; Habermas → defence of reason/universal communication
Critical Theory / Neo-Marxism	Goes beyond economics to examine culture, ideology, media and domination	Horkheimer, Adorno, Marcuse, Habermas	Culture industry, ideology, communicative action	Can be overly pessimistic about mass culture and agency	Weber → multidimensional domination; Giddens → agency; Interactionists → active meaning-making
Structuration Theory	Structure and agency are mutually constitutive	Anthony Giddens	Duality of structure, agency, structuration	Abstract and difficult to operationalise empirically	Marx → structural constraints; Interactionists → micro agency; Bourdieu → habitus/field
Bourdieu's Practice Theory	Social practices emerge from interaction of habitus, capital and field	Pierre Bourdieu	Economic, cultural, social & symbolic capital; habitus; field; symbolic violence	Concepts can be difficult to measure; may understate conscious agency	Giddens → greater emphasis on agency/reflexivity; Marx → stronger economic/class emphasis
Rational Choice Theory	Individuals are strategic actors who choose actions based on preferences, incentives and constraints	James Coleman, George Homans	Rational actor, utility, incentives	Underplays norms, emotions, culture and structural constraints	Durkheim → norms; Weber → value-oriented action; Bourdieu → habitus

2. High-Value UPSC Criticism Pairs

If You Write...	Add This Thinker as Counterpoint
Marx → economic/class conflict	Weber → status + party + multidimensional stratification
Marx → economic determinism	Weber → ideas/religion can influence economic behaviour
Marx → macro structure	Symbolic Interactionists → micro interaction and meaning
Functionalism → consensus/order	Marx → conflict and domination
Functionalism → stability/status quo	Dahrendorf → conflict is inherent in authority relations
Functionalism → equilibrium	Merton → dysfunction + unintended consequences
Positivism → objective/scientific sociology	Weber → subjective meaning / Verstehen
Positivism → observable facts	Phenomenology → lived experience/consciousness
Weber → subjective meaning	Durkheim → objective social facts
Phenomenology → subjective experience	Marx → objective structural/material constraints
Symbolic Interactionism → micro interaction	Marx → macro power/class structures
Ethnomethodology → everyday order	Marx/Weber → institutional power and authority
Rational Choice → rational calculation	Durkheim → norms and collective morality
Postmodernism → fragmented reality	Habermas → possibility of rational/universal communication
Postmodernism → discourse/power	Marx → material/economic relations
Structure dominates agency	Giddens → structure ↔ agency
Agency dominates structure	Giddens/Bourdieu → agency is enabled/constrained by structure
Feminism → patriarchy	Crenshaw → gender interacts with other axes of inequality
Class-based explanation	Weber → class + status + party
Economic capital	Bourdieu → cultural/social/symbolic capital

3. The 4-Angle Framework for UPSC Answers

1. **POSITIVIST** — "*What objective social forces cause this?*"
→ **Comte, Durkheim**
2. **INTERPRETATIVE / PHENOMENOLOGICAL** — "*What does this situation mean to the people experiencing it?*"
→ **Weber, Schutz, Mead, Blumer**
3. **CONFLICT** — "*Who has power, who benefits and who is disadvantaged?*"
→ **Marx, Dahrendorf, C. Wright Mills**
4. **FUNCTIONALIST** — "*What function does this institution/practice perform for the social system?*"
→ **Durkheim, Parsons, Merton**

4. UPSC Analytical Formula

Structure → Meaning → Function → Power/Conflict

Example: Religion

- **Durkheim:** Religion creates social solidarity.
- **Marx:** Religion can legitimise domination.
- **Weber:** Religious ideas can shape economic action.
- **Schutz:** Examine the lived meaning of religion for believers.
- **Interactionism:** Religious identity is produced through everyday interaction.

Result

Instead of writing only:

"According to Marx, religion is an instrument of domination."

Write:

"While Marx highlights the role of religion in legitimising class domination, Weber provides a contrasting interpretation by demonstrating how religious ideas can themselves influence economic behaviour, as illustrated by the Protestant ethic."

This creates **thinker-to-thinker linkage**, which makes the answer analytical rather than merely descriptive.